

# **Rensselaer Union**

## **The Bylaws of the Rensselaer Union Graduate Council**

As amended: April 21, 2026

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## **ARTICLE I: PREAMBLE**

These Bylaws supersede all previous Bylaws of the Graduate Student Council, effective upon adoption of the Graduate Student Council.

## **ARTICLE II: PURPOSE**

- (1) The Graduate Student Council (hereafter, the Council) is the elected representative body of the Graduate Students and the graduate legislative branch of the Rensselaer Union.
- (2) The Council shall be responsible for initiating all legislative action within the Rensselaer Union pertaining only to Graduate Students and not specifically within the domain of the Student Senate or the Executive Board.
- (3) The Council shall act as an advisory board to the Graduate School.
- (4) The Council shall ensure adequate representation to other governing bodies by appointing members to other committees as prescribed by the Rensselaer Union Constitution.

## **ARTICLE III: ELIGIBILITY**

- (1) Students who are enrolled in the Graduate School and who are pursuing a graduate degree at Rensselaer shall be eligible to run for and hold office on the Graduate Student Council. Students who do not meet these requirements at any time shall not be considered to be on the Council and their office shall be considered vacant.
- (2) Appointments made by the Graduate Student Council shall be subject to the same eligibility requirements.

## **ARTICLE IV: MEMBERSHIP**

- (1) Only students meeting the above eligibility requirements in Article III may run for and hold office on the Graduate Student Council.
- (2) The voting membership of the Graduate Student Council shall consist of all Graduate Senators and all Graduate Representatives.
  - (a) Seven members shall be elected as Graduate Senators to serve on the Student Senate in addition to the Council.
  - (b) Seven members shall be elected as Graduate Representatives at large.
  - (c) One additional Graduate Representative shall be elected by the Black Graduate Student Association.
  - (d) The Council shall make it possible for each school of Rensselaer to be represented on the Council by at least one Graduate Senator or Graduate Representative.
    - (i) For the purposes of this document, "school of Rensselaer" shall be one of:
      - (A) Information Technology
      - (B) Lally School of Management and Technology

- (C) School of Architecture
  - (D) School of Engineering
  - (E) School of Humanities and Social Sciences
  - (F) School of Science
- (ii) The Graduate Council shall make reasonable efforts to ensure that both Masters' and Co-term students of the Union Graduate community are adequately represented in the Graduate Council. The Council will endeavor to ensure that at least one Graduate Senator position and at least one Graduate Representative position of the Council are occupied by Masters' and/or Co-term students.
  - (iii) If the at-large Graduate Council membership is full (i.e. all Graduate Senators and all at-large Graduate Representatives have been elected) without any representation from the Masters' and/or Co-term student cohort and any eligible student of the subject cohort wishes to be represented on the Council, then each year, a single additional at-will Graduate Representative seat will be opened for any interested applicant from the subject unrepresented cohort. These at-will open seats shall not be opened by default: the requirement for the open seat shall be determined not before the completion of Grand Marshal Week elections each year and the open seat shall cease to exist at the conclusion of each term. Once opened, the seat shall be filled according to the standard procedure for vacancies as detailed in Article V, Clause 5.
- (3) The nonvoting membership of the Graduate Student Council shall consist of:
- (a) The Dean of the Graduate School or their designee.
  - (b) All representatives to other bodies appointed by the Council, if not already voting members.
  - (c) The Grand Marshal and the President of the Union, if they meet the eligibility criteria stated in Article III above.
  - (d) The president or their designated representative of any other departmental graduate representative body or independent graduate organization at Rensselaer, that advocates for graduate interests and/or conducts social events, primarily to serve the graduate community at Rensselaer. Such non-voting representation may include and shall not be limited to:
    - (i) The different departmental graduate councils or graduate student advisory bodies operating under the Schools of Engineering (viz. ECSE GC, BME GC, MANE Student Advisory Council and others), Science (viz. Physics GC, and others), HASS (viz. STS GC, CogSci GSA and others) and Lally School of Management (Lally GC and ITWS GC).
    - (ii) The different independent graduate organizations, operating in Rensselaer, from time to time (viz. Grad SWE, Students with Families and others).
    - (iii) The different Union-recognized graduate bodies, active in the Rensselaer Union, from time to time (viz. BGSA, Bangladeshi Students Association and others).
- Further, such non-voting representation, as given by Article IV.3.iv above, shall not be ex-officio and shall require a formal written request from the president of the

respective graduate body or organization to the President of the Graduate Student Council. All such requests shall be automatically approved and the Graduate Student Council shall not have any discretionary authority to deny them under any pretext.

- (e) The immediately outgoing (lame-duck) President of the Graduate Student Council shall serve as a non-voting, ex-officio member of the Council, for the duration of the incumbent term, following their completion of office.
- (f) The Graduate Council may, by a simple majority vote, engage the services of any former President(s) or Officer(s) of the Council, to serve in a strictly non-voting and advisory capacity, for specific projects of limited duration. Such engagements shall be limited to situations where the Council determines that the former Presidents' or Officers' experience and expertise would be beneficial and the same shall be documented.

*Note 1.* Such non-voting positions of the Graduate Student Council, as described in Article IV.3.v and IV.3.vi above, shall not be considered as violations to the Eligibility requirements, as given in Article III, earlier.

## **ARTICLE V: ELECTIONS AND TERMS OF OFFICE**

- (1) Council elections shall be held during Grand Marshal Week and shall be run by the Student Senate.
  - (a) Students shall take office immediately upon announcement of election results, at which time the term of office for previous members shall expire.
- (2) A Council member's term of office shall end if, prior to Grand Marshal Week, the Council member:
  - (a) resigns;
  - (b) is removed; or
  - (c) graduates or otherwise leaves Rensselaer.
- (3) Removal of a member from the Council, or from any appointed or elective position, shall require concurrence of two thirds of the remaining voting membership of the Council.
- (4) Resignation or removal from the Student Senate shall constitute removal from the Council. A Senator removed in this way may apply for a position as Member at Large, if such position is vacant.
- (5) Vacancies on the Council and appointments to other bodies may be filled by appointment with the approval of two thirds of the voting membership of the Council.
  - (a) Applications must be solicited publicly at least ten days in advance of any appointment.
  - (b) The Council shall offer to interview all applicants for a position prior to filling that position.
  - (c) An appointment shall be valid for the remainder of the term of office.
- (6) In the event of the death of a Council member before the natural end of their term of office, said office shall be held open out of respect for one month.

## ARTICLE VI: OFFICERS

- (1) As soon as practical, following the annual elections, the newly elected Graduate Student Council shall meet to elect from its voting membership a Vice President, a Treasurer and a Secretary, whose duties shall include, but are not limited to, those outlined below.
  - (a) The Graduate Council President shall call this meeting, and preside over the election of all other officers.
  - (b) The previous Graduate Council President shall be in attendance at the meeting to observe.
- (2) The Vice President shall:
  - (a) act as President in their absence, if no President Pro Tempore has been designated;
  - (b) coordinate the operations of the Council not provided elsewhere in these Bylaws;
  - (c) monitor the activities of the various committees; and
  - (d) be responsible for maintaining electronic communication channels of the Council.
- (3) The Treasurer shall:
  - (a) handle all monies derived from the Graduate Fee, and all other income;
  - (b) handle all purchases and other monetary transactions of the Council;
  - (c) authorize members to charge against the Council's account for amounts less than \$50. Expenditures exceeding this amount require a majority approval of the Council;
  - (d) keep a record of all Council expenses; and
  - (e) make monthly reports to the Council of its financial status.
- (4) The Secretary shall:
  - (a) take minutes to all meetings and distribute them to Council members.
    - (i) Minutes shall be reviewed and approved by a majority vote of the Council.
  - (b) be responsible for advertising meetings and events of the Council.

The election process for the President follows the same procedure as the other officers when that position is vacant. The previous Graduate Council President runs this meeting until a new Graduate Council President has been elected.

The responsibilities of the newly elected President are outlined below.

- (1) The President shall:
  - (a) be one of the officers of the Rensselaer Union;
  - (b) act as primary spokesperson for the Council;
  - (c) preside over all Council meetings, or appoint a President Pro Tempore to do so if unable to attend;
  - (d) act as representative to the Board of Trustees, or, if unable to do so, appoint another member of the Council to this position; and
  - (e) act as representative to the Rensselaer Alumni Association Board of Trustees.

- (f) act as a liaison to the Student Senate.

## **ARTICLE VII: MEETINGS**

- (1) Meetings shall be held at least once per month during normal academic periods.
  - (a) Telephone and electronic voting is permitted as needed between meetings. Any decisions made by a phone or vote must be reviewed at the next meeting. Email or other electronic messaging services are both permissible options for electronic voting.
- (2) The President shall call meetings and publicly post the agenda no less than one business day prior to the meeting.
- (3) Meetings are open to all students unless closed by a majority vote of the Council.
- (4) Council members shall be notified at least three days in advance of a regular meeting.
- (5) Quorum is necessary to conduct business. Quorum shall consist of a majority of the active voting membership of the Council. The President, or their designee, must be present for quorum to be in effect.
- (6) All matters, unless specified otherwise by these Bylaws, shall be decided by a majority of those voting members present.
- (7) An emergency meeting may be called at the request of any Council member with the consent of the majority of voting members.
  - (a) Emergency meetings must be held within three days.
  - (b) It shall be the responsibility of the requesting member to obtain majority consent and to give all voting members at least 24 hours notice of the meeting.
  - (c) The requesting member, or their designee, shall preside over the meeting.

## **ARTICLE VIII: GRADUATE STUDENT COUNCIL RESPONSIBILITIES**

- (1) The Graduate Student Council shall have duties and responsibilities including, but not limited to, those listed below.
  - (a) assist and advise the Student Senate on academic issues;
  - (b) work with the Institute to address issues related to graduate academics and Teaching and Research Assistants;
  - (c) coordinate admissions activities with the Graduate School and Graduate Admissions Office;
  - (d) act as liaison and coordinate communications between the Council and prospective Graduate Students;
  - (e) include and advise the liaisons to the:
    - (i) Center for Career and Professional Development;
    - (ii) Event Planning Committee; and
    - (iii) Graduate Research Symposium Taskforce.
  - (f) coordinate social functions for the Graduate Student Body; and

- (g) nominate a graduating graduate student to speak at commencement.
- (2) The Council shall have the authority to create ad hoc committees, as deemed necessary, by a majority vote.
  - (a) Any Graduate Student may serve on a Council committee.
  - (b) Committee chairs shall be appointed by the Council President.
  - (c) Each committee shall be responsible for maintaining records of its activities.
    - (i) Committee chairs shall make a report of committee activities to the Council upon request.
- (3) Permanent committees shall include the Events Committee and the Marketing Committee.
  - (a) The Events Committee shall be responsible for organizing, planning, and running all Graduate Student Council events.
  - (b) The Marketing Committee shall be responsible for advertising and promoting the meetings and activities of the Council.

## **ARTICLE IX: AMENDMENTS**

- (1) Amendments to the Graduate Student Council Bylaws must be proposed at least one week before their adoption by the Graduate Student Council.
  - (a) Adoption of an amendment by the Council shall require a two thirds majority of the voting membership of the Council.
  - (b) After adoption, the Graduate Council shall present any changes to the Student Senate in a timely manner.